

| By Sharda Ugra |

Wasim Akram, wearing a pink shirt and his charming-rogue face, is explaining what kind of team can hope to win cricket's short sprint championship, the World Twenty20, which will last all of 16 days, from swearing-in ceremonies to silverware distribution. It is, he declares, in a fragrant burst of Urdu and cricket, the team that has "*pressure lene ki salahiyat*". The ability to absorb pressure. Okay, great, thanks Waz. Looks like it's a done deal then, for

TEAM INDIA, LED BY A NEW SKIPPER, WAS THE SHOCK WINNER IN THE 2007 WORLD TWENTY20



Mahendra Singh Dhoni and his boys.

Frankly, whatever anyone else says about pressure, there's only one team which plays with the knowledge that if they botch things up, a billion minds could seriously be expected to unravel. Does any other Parliament take note of their captain flashing at a wide one? Or nightly news anywhere else ignore unemployment statistics because the fast bowler trundled in one night like a stoned elephant? (Just to be nice, let's not start on effigy-burning or stoning of houses).

It's enough to just say that pressure and the Indian cricket team know each other intimately. Pressure goes wherever the team does and doesn't

time the title is theirs to lose.

India were such shock winners in the 2007 World Twenty20 in South Africa that it is fair to say they shocked even themselves. They had played only one T20 International before that and their faithful were only half-paying attention. When they returned home, they found themselves on an open-topped bus and their country madly, incurably in love with this microwaved form of its national obsession.

In 2009, India is at the World T20 as one of two rising forces in the game. It jostles with South Africa in wanting to knock Australia off its shaky perch. It is expected to be a front-runner, to lead the charge, to dominate. India has

EVER SINCE WINNING THE 2007 WORLD TWENTY20, INDIA HAVE RISEN IN THE GAME AND ARE NOW EXPECTED TO CALL THE SHOTS AND DOMINATE THE 2009 EVENT.

even need a ticket. Like now, when the cricketing universe is in England with a world trophy to play for. It's the only one Australia is not defending. South Africa is trying to stomp on everyone. Sri Lanka to shake off the nightmare of Lahore, Pakistan to shake off all that followed, the West Indies to be taken seriously. But still India *aka* the "Rockstars of Cricket" remain the hot ticket, because they've arrived with an accompanying circus, their deranged fans and overwhelming expectations.

And an added encumbrance—this

rarely gone into a major event with such a large target painted on its backs. Though remember Akram's *pressure lene ke salahiyat*? By now that target has almost become a pattern on their team shirts, particularly their new shade of moody blue.

By now, leave aside impressing Akram, India's ability to absorb pressure should have earned them lucrative endorsements from sponge manufacturers. In its warm-up T20 match against Pakistan at the Oval, played to a noisy, full house in the mid-